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Greg Thomas

Greg Thomas is a 1985 graduate of Hamilton College and an astute observer of the current jazz scene. His writing has appeared in the Village Voice *and the* London Guardian Observer*, and he was founding Editor-in-Chief of* Harlem World *magazine. Greg and his wife, Jewel Kinch-Thomas, currently promote jazz events through their company, G&J Productions.*

Greg was interviewed in Clinton, New York on October 11, 2014, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College talking to Greg Thomas, Hamilton class of '85. And I should tell you that I have described you as a jazz entrepreneur.

GT: I like that.

MR: Do you like that? Because I wasn't quite sure. I know I'm aware of some of the things you've done but probably not all. But you are a person that got bit by the jazz bug.

GT: Yes, big time. Big time. Even before Hamilton, in high school is where I got bit by the jazz bug. And that happened, I actually know the moment. I know the moment it happened. It was at a Tottenville High School stage band concert. Mason Ashe, also a graduate of Hamilton class of '85, he and I went to junior high school together in Staten Island, Dreyfus Junior High School, then we went to high school together. Because it was junior high school we actually went to ninth grade at Dreyfus. So we went to Tottenville in tenth grade. So at the end of our sophomore year in tenth grade, we attend this stage band concert. And they played some Spyro Gyra, they played some Basie, they played some Steely Dan, and it just blew us away. It blew us away. We loved it. The expression, the way the instruments seemed to talk and speak to each other and express emotions, I mean I might not have put it in those terms then, you know, it was just exciting. So at the end of the concert they were sitting there and Mason says, "I've got to pick up my guitar again." Because he played guitar. And I said, "I've got to pick up something." I'd never played. I mean I played recorder you know, in elementary school, but nothing else. So I decided to pick up the alto saxophone. So I borrowed an alto, a Selmer Bundy from school. I was fortunate to go to a high school that had a really strong music program so they had a closet that had all kinds of instruments. So I took an alto sax home and started to learn. And in my junior year I was in the concert band and the — let's see, the concert band, that was the main band. And my goal was to get into the stage band that first inspired me. By my senior year I got into the stage band on alto, and also the symphonic band that played, I guess, light classics.

MR: Right. And then you ran into Clark Terry here.

GT: Oh my, you are fast forwarding to the next epiphany. Oh man, yeah. Clark Terry. This was in April of 1994. And you know it's funny, last night at the concert featuring Dick Hyman, Randy Sandke — a group led by Hyman and featuring yourself — I got a chance to see for the first time in 30 years Don Cantwell, who I studied saxophone with here, and who was the head of the Hamilton jazz band. And so he made arrangements for Clark to come. Now he reminded me last night that the fraternity — is it Delta Upsilon? — DU — at least they were based down at Bundy then. I used to hang out with those guys. I lived in Bundy. I wasn't a member of the fraternity but they were creative guys, artistic, and a bunch of them, we formed a band called Delta Bop. And, let's see, just to go through a quick, before we get to Clark, Delta Bop. Delta Bop had Joe Duffus on drums; Bill Dentzer on trumpet and piano; Jamey Rhind, who wasn't a member of the fraternity but he played piano; Mason played guitar; Paul Williams on bass; and there was another gentleman with blonde hair who played trumpet also but I don't think he was in the group and I don't remember his name. But anyway Mr. Cantwell says that that fraternity in part made it possible for Clark to be here. They came up with some funding, which I didn't even remember. So Mr. Cantwell made arrangements for Clark to come. He played his own arrangements with his big band — I mean of his arrangements that he used for his big band. And I remember, I mean I always did, when there were certain speakers who came and certain musicians who came, I would always do like serious research on them — listen to their recordings and find out about them. So I read about Clark Terry and Clark Terry, I mean, Basie, Ellington, Quincy Jones, you know, he had his group with Bob Brookmeyer, you know, I mean just classic recordings from the 60s with the Oscar Peterson Trio. You know, just I mean, and just a phenomenal, phenomenal trumpet player. A master, and I think because of his education work, a grand master. Because he has not only demonstrated mastery of the instrument but he's passed on the legacy to others who themselves are masters and became masters. I mean his first student was Quincy Jones. Miles Davis looked up to Clark. So anyway what I remember from that event was we went to dinner — I think it was the night before — we went to dinner, and it was myself, Don Cantwell and a few other members of the band. And I was sitting next to Clark and I was just — I couldn't say anything. I was just in awe of him. So he's like, "So tell me about yourself," you know, and made me feel comfortable and relaxed, which was good because I was to share a melody with him. So we got a chance to play in a rehearsal, but it was nothing like being in the chapel actually playing. And I really described it almost like a mystical experience. Because in the chapel when you play, the acoustics are wonderful in the chapel — the Hamilton College chapel. So it felt like his sound was surrounding me like a cloud of joy or something like that. It was just — I

mean it was literally like being in heaven. And I mean I'm telling you from that point my playing improved automatically in this sense: I began to project more of my own personality, you know, I wasn't holding back as much. Be yourself. Say what you've got to say. I mean hey, I've played with Clark Terry so why not?

MR: That's a powerful moment in playing beside the fellas from that generation is indescribable. It's like this really intense education. And sometimes you don't realize it until a little bit after when you reflect on what that was like.

GT: Right. I mean it's like truly living jazz history, you know? I mean he not only played with the greats — I mean I had a recording of his in high school and it was him, and it was a bootleg. It was a Dinah Washington recording. And it had Clark, Clifford Brown and Maynard Ferguson playing together. And it was just incredible. So I mean I knew who he was. So I'll give you a quick anecdote. I was very close with Duke Ellington's nephew, Ruth Ellington's son, Michael James, who was one of the top protégés of Albert Murray, who I presume we'll talk some more about, I hope. And he would tell me these stories about his time, not only with Duke, which was enough, but I mean Johnny Hodges was his Godfather. I mean he would hang on Paul Gonsalves, he was at the recording session that Duke did "Train" I mean stuff like that. So he told me he was close to Papa Jo Jones. And he told me that one time Papa Jo, I think they were at the Vanguard and they were checking out, what's his name, Philly Joe Jones. And what Papa Jo Jones would say to Mike is, "Hear that? That's it. That's me." You know, that's this one, that's that one. And saying that they all were on stage with him at the same time. Because those influences come through. So I mean talking about Clark Terry, I mean you're talking about someone who embodies what the music is about. So it was just a profound experience for me.

MR: I recall being surprised I guess, early on when I started doing these interviews, when a person of Clark's stature, a number of them would basically hit me up for a gig afterwards, after the interview. Now that sounds too pejorative. But it made me realize that these gentlemen, as much as they were revered by you and I and the jazz-loving public, were still trying to make a living.

GT: Absolutely.

MR: And they were not — I think I had this idea that a guy like Clark Terry and those fellas, they got it made now. They could choose their gigs and stay home if they want, which usually was not true. They still had to work.

GT: That's right. Definitely.

MR: So going from Hamilton, what was your major here?

GT: Public Policy, which combined government, economics and philosophy. And my minor was music, where we went through the history of European classical music but also played in different ensembles and in this group I mentioned before, Delta Bop, we did a

winter semester, the project was to play and do a concert, which we did, which was cool, a lot of fun.

MR: Did you ever play any of the frat parties and that kind of stuff?

GT: Occasionally. I remember one time we played a frat party and it was so loud, and there were no monitors, so I couldn't even hear myself. But they seemed to be able to hear themselves.

MR: Yeah they can get pretty wild.

GT: Yeah.

MR: When you left here, did you know what you wanted to do?

GT: Well while I was here I thought I wanted to be a lawyer, which was one of the reasons I chose Public Policy, that seemed to be practical — public policy dealing with the legislative process, various issues, you know that deal with the government and economics and the social dimension of things, with certain ethical issues underpinning it and all that kind of stuff in terms of the different disciplines that comprise that interdisciplinary major. But by the time I was a senior, I didn't necessarily want to go that route. I didn't want to go to law school. So many of my friends were going that route. So I really frankly wasn't sure when I left what I wanted to do, no I wasn't really sure, no.

MR: But you found a way to work in jazz as a writer and a producer. How did that sort of evolve?

GT: Well let's see. Well the writer is first. Back in 1989 there was a publication called *Urban Profile* that was started by Keith Clinkscales and Leonard Burnett — their first magazine. They later went on to jointly put out five magazines, *Savoy Magazine*, they both have very successful careers. Len Burnett is now I think the chief revenue officer — they create these titles — for *Uptown Magazine*, which is based in Harlem but that covers goings on for I'd say the upper middle class black society, the black community in major cities — you know, Atlanta, Chicago, New York and like that. So for this publication I wrote an article and it was an advocacy piece — why black folks need to support jazz. So that was my very first professional piece. And I freelanced. Actually in '91 I began as a staff writer at the *City Sun*, which was a black-owned newspaper in Brooklyn that was a very good newspaper, you know, defunct after a few years. But I mean I've written for the *Guardian Observer*; for various online publications from "Salon" to "Root," Africana.com when it was around, "Black World Today"; and in print publications, I was a *New York Daily News* jazz columnist for a few years; *Savoy Magazine* I wrote for, *American Legacy* magazine I did some writing for, and a number of others. So the writing has been I guess the longest thing, and considering the way the internet has upended publishing and various industries, not just publishing but every industry really. Certainly being a journalist, unless you are one of the holders of a coveted staff position

at a really well-healed publication, it's really hard to make a living at free-lance writing. So I've always had to supplement, you know, teaching and doing other things.

MR: Right. I've often wondered, is it harder to make a living as a jazz musician or as a jazz journalist?

GT: It's relative. I would say it's — these days it probably is hard to be a jazz musician because you have situations where you have so many musicians and so relatively few places to play, and particularly places that pay anything decent. I mean there was a time I hear about or read about, or I've read about and have been told about, because I've done a bunch of interviews myself for the National Jazz Museum of Harlem, their "Harlem Speaks" series, I co-produced that and did dozens of interviews. And you hear these accounts of clubs here and there in various cities, and how it was just a part of the whole scene. That changed in the 60s, 70s, and 80s. You have these ups and downs. You have these waves of course, of where jazz is more or less recognized and appreciated, but it's rough for jazz musicians. Especially when you have so many jazz musicians, young jazz musicians, coming out of jazz programs. There's more jazz musicians coming out of jazz programs than there are bands — well not bands — but I'll say places, venues, for them to work I think. So that's problematic.

MR: Yeah. Winard Harper was saying the same thing. And it's rather ironic that in one sense jazz has become much more popular and healthy in academia, but that curve going up is sort of matched by the curve going down.

GT: Right, right. So I think the key would be to make sure that those students are prepared. Say listen, it's great to be an instrumentalist and to know how to do that and to be as good as you can with that, but that in the current marketplace you need to definitely be well-rounded, which a liberal arts education is supposed to give you, and to have some specific skill sets that you can apply in other areas other than music, but even in music there are any number of things that are needed. Certainly fundamentally these people will hopefully be jazz fans all of their life and bring others into the music, even if it's just their own children. But there is other things that's needed. You know when you talk about an industry you have different parts of that industry and how people fit. You know musicians often disparage critics. I consider myself a jazz writer though, and I'm a jazz critic to a certain extent, I think in a neutral to a positive sense, but because critics are so bedeviled by a negative connotation I think I lean toward jazz journalist.

MR: Okay.

GT: But I mean there's a function for that. There's a critical function which basically is the go-between between the musicians and the public. Now some musicians would say we don't need that. I mean the public, if they hear it then they can form their own impression. Well sometimes they might not hear it unless there is some vehicles,

publications, individuals, who are promoting it, publicizing it, you know letting folks know. So the critical function is to take those, you know the artist's intent plus the codes and standards and traditions of the particular art form, and then translate all of that in a way that a general layperson can understand it and relate to it, and hopefully connect with it. I mean that's the critical function I think. So it serves a purpose. But getting back to my other point, I mean there are people you need on the business side. You need people to own venues. You need people to manage artists. You have venues that have their own functions that are played in a venue. There are so many levels. So there's a lot that can be done, you know. If you go on to law school you can do entertainment law, you know, and help out. So there's all kinds of ways of being involved with the music and continuing to support it, other than just by being a working musician.

MR: Yeah. And I'd like to think that the people in those positions do better at it if they were musicians, or if they are musicians.

GT: I would think so. Because there's a certain sensitivity that you have. There's a certain appreciation that you have, of what it actually takes to become good at playing an instrument. And it takes devotion and dedication, like anything. But you're talking about something that, there's a learning curve to it.

MR: As an organizer or booker of gigs, you must have these situations where you'd love to pay this particular musician some good bread.

GT: Yeah man, absolutely.

MR: But you have economic realities that you're dealing with — the clubs and all that stuff. So that must be a little awkward at times.

GT: Yeah, it is. It is. I've been in a position where my production company — I have a production company with my partner in life, Jewel Kinch-Thomas, called G&J Productions, and we have produced any number of places: the Wainwright House in Rye, New York; Aaron Davis Hall in Harlem; Ginny's Supper Club, which is below the Red Rooster in Harlem; Mist, Harlem on 116th between Lenox and Fifth, we did a jazz Sunday brunch there; any number of other places — Friar's Club also. And so we've been in a position where we've paid artists directly, but sometimes we work with venues and it's the venue's responsibility to pay the musicians. And you always run up against the economic reality of, okay, you have the musicians' fees, and then the venue and the producers have other costs. There's marketing costs. There's the cost of if you're in a venue that serves food you've got servers and you've got food costs and you've got overhead, and all that stuff is taken into consideration. So sometimes you just cannot afford to hire certain musicians. And there are times when you have to give what you can afford to give, but that's not necessarily what artistically the real value — I mean it's a fabulous place that we've had, and they need the work and we have a certain budget, and

sometimes that's just what it comes down to. Yeah, so I mean yeah, you're right. Sometimes it does hurt.

MR: And then the musician has to decide well, I could do this or I could stay home or, you know.

GT: Yeah. Or maybe not do it and get something better.

MR: Right.

GT: Yeah.

MR: Did you ever have musicians say okay I'll do it and then get something better and then — I know it happens around here.

GT: Okay. There have been some sidemen. In other words, the main artists we've worked with, I'm trying to think, I don't think there's been the lead artist who has done that. But some of their sidemen. They've had to replace sidemen because the sideman comes up with other things.

MR: "You know the drummer I was having on board?" —

GT: Exactly. Right.

MR: Well some things never change, it doesn't matter where you are.

GT: Right.

MR: I wanted to talk about, I read this about you, under the banner of "Race and Jazz," to shed light on the way that race has bedeviled the jazz discourse in the actual lives of jazz musicians. It's a topic that gets written about a lot, and I'm wondering what you're thinking about it at this point.

GT: Well the intent of that series in *All About Jazz* was to, frankly to use the issue of race to point the way to culture. Because race biologically speaking is an illusion unless you're talking about the human race. It almost sounds like a cliché but it's true. But race certainly has — there's a psychological and social and behavioral dimension to race that's very real. Because if you believe, let's take you Monk. If I make certain judgments about you based on the pigment of your skin or your height or your weight or some attribute like that, if I make certain presumptions and then treat you in a certain manner because of that, then you have to then adjust yourself based on my belief and my behavior towards you based on attributes that, in a larger sense, are immaterial and should not be the basis upon judging, or assuming certain behaviors, or assuming certain values you know. If, you know, if you have this skin pigment therefore you think or behave in a certain fashion. I mean it sounds absurd because it is. It is absurd. But I'm leading to the culture piece.

MR: Okay, well and also you can make assumptions about, if we're talking about musicians, where you're going to be more likely to play in a certain way.

GT: Oh yeah. Oh that's true. But these days that's usually not the case because there's such diversity of styles within the music that it's hard to just look at someone and say well they play such-and-such a style. That's hard these days I'd say. But getting back to what I was saying about race and culture, so race itself as a biological reality is an illusion you know. But because race has become a part of the way people look at things, the way some people look at things and the way people then behave towards others, then that gets in the mix so you have to deal with that. I think a much better to look at human interaction, group behavior, values, traditions, practices, modes of passing down those through education, myths and rituals that are related to those things, is culture. So the issue of race is, so it's like the third rail they say in American discussion, in American discourse. But I was willing to take the risk of dealing with that because one, I have thought about and read about these issues for decades. I did some graduate work at NYU in American Studies, a doctoral program, in which it allowed me to continue my interdisciplinary work that I started here at Hamilton. So I went into more depth in literature and anthropology and history in particular, both the subjects themselves as well as a critical body of work and thought in those areas, which has given me a really broad view of these issues. I know that personally, and this is something that I tell in the very first entry into that series, the first essay, which I called if I remember correctly, "Jazz Versus Racism." You see the series is "Race and Jazz." But "Jazz Versus Racism" was the title of the first piece. So my first line is jazz, help me to not become a racist, or something along that line. And it told about my time here at Hamilton where, because I was studying in depth about enslavement, the middle passage, and those details. I got angry. I mean, you know, like in the late 70s, while in high school, watching *Roots*. It got you angry. But, you know, really studying this stuff. So but what happened, and with Mr. Louis Farrakhan and the Nation of Islam was pretty big at the time, around the time that Jesse Jackson was running for president and that kind of thing. You know, and we'd listen to tapes here, and that kind of thing. But the thing that never allowed me to jump over the cliff and become a racist, and I don't believe the canard that if you're black you can't be a racist because race is about power relations. I don't buy that. I mean not that race isn't about power relations, but it's not just about that. You could have a point of view about someone based on their physical attributes — that ain't got a damn thing to do with whether or not you have power over them. Now if you have some kind of power over them it becomes worse, which is what black people have had to deal with for a long time. But you can still have a point of view about other people based on those kind of attributes and not have that. So I don't buy that particular argument. So I got to a point where I had to actually make a choice. Am I going to, based on this anger, based on this history, am I going to actually start to dislike white people, you know? And the thing that

297 didn't allow me to make that leap was the music. Because I loved Phil Woods and his
298 playing. Because I loved Paul Desmond. I loved Zoot Sims. And that was like a shield
299 that protected me against falling prey to that kind of thinking, man.
300 MR: That's wonderful to hear. And I have, it's not exactly the same, but my introduction to
301 the black race was through — you know I grew up in a suburb where there was one
302 African American student who was sort of probably bussed in from inner-city Rochester
303 and of course he was on the basketball team. And it was my introduction to another race
304 of people, was really through Cannonball Adderley and Count Basie. So it's really great
305 to hear that that music can surround this.
306 GT: And, if you would allow me, because how we language things, how we describe things, is
307 so important. So I would amend what you just said and say the first time you met a
308 particular ethnic group or cultural group, which some called going back some called
309 Negro Americans, to black Americans, to African Americans, would have been that, like
310 I said, race is not real in that sense. So I don't believe that there is a black race or a white
311 race. In that same piece that I'm talking about, I have a short portion where I talk about
312 Phil Woods, Paul Desmond and Zoot Sims. And I describe their ethnic background. Part
313 Jewish, part German, and then I have in parenthesis, I say, you know isn't it like
314 shameful to reduce them to the word "white" where they have this diversity and variety
315 in their backgrounds? You know what I mean? So I don't use that kind of terminology
316 because I think it reinforces and reinscribes the notion that race is actually real. I don't
317 buy it.
318 MR: Yeah. I have a marvelous — Jon Hendricks said, I'll have to show it to you sometime.
319 GT: No, you have it on the wall. Go ahead. Oh you want me to say it?
320 MR: Yeah. Go ahead.
321 GT: I just read it, and since I visited here before, I was here in 2010 for my 25th class reunion I
322 remember seeing that. And Jon Hendricks says in his Hamilton College Jazz Archive
323 interview, "When someone asks me about race I say 'when does it start?'" Jon Hendricks,
324 the master of vocalese. I've had my own interactions with Jon Hendricks and I've
325 actually written on his vocalese work which, I think he's the total master of vocalese an
326 example of a work like "Joy Spring." His vocalese rendition of Clifford Brown's "Joy
327 Spring" as performed by Manhattan Transfer on their Grammy-award-winning recording
328 of vocalese is a masterpiece in that particular subgenre. So Jon Hendricks, a very learned
329 man. I think he went to law school for a while. He's very well read, and it finds its way
330 into his body of lyrics, vocalese lyrics. But he's also down to earth. He's also got the, as
331 they say, the street experience. He's got all of that. So he's able to bring a full dimension
332 of all that into his work.

MR: Well getting back to when you produce concerts and so forth. Are you conscious of the people that you book in a whole season or for a particular event? Because we both sort of agree that there's no such thing as race, but I can't say this question without it. Are you conscious, like gee I have booked almost all white players this season, or I have booked almost all black players this season. You know when I get the musicians for this Fallcoming jazz concert, that's been going on for 23 years and there's been many years where all the musicians were white, partly because they played in a style that our founder Milt Fillius liked.

GT: And you find —

MR: I don't know if I have a question here. But I wonder if —

GT: If race, so-called, is a consideration either retrospectively or prospectively? Not race per se, because I've hired men, women, black, white, you know Latino, Asian — and they've been mixtures in the band, which is always great. But you do have to take a look at fit. When I say fit, fit could be stylistic fit, fit could be generational, because who's your audience? As a writer it's like you've got to be aware of who your audience is so when you're booking/producing, who's your audience? Now your audience in your case is varied. And a jazz audience is certainly hard to define, but when we book in Harlem for example, you know you're usually talking about boomers and older. You've got some Gen Xers yeah. You usually don't have a lot of young people, and the young people you do have, either they were introduced to the music by their parents and the event is just something they can do that's fun. Or they are musicians, they've studied music. You know a lot of times those are the things that when we see young people. But, you know, what's your theme? See one of the things we do for G&J is we have different themes that we use to hang the events on. So instead of just presenting such-and-such a group led by such-and-such a person (which we've done also) you have a certain theme that you're fitting groups in for a series. So we had something called "Cutting Up," which was based on the cutting content. So you have the leaders on the same instrument, with the rhythm section and they're playing tunes together, and they're trading fours and trading eights and that kind of thing. It's really fun but to use the whole competition angle it's kind of a marketing tool of sorts. And we've had, oh man, we've had several of those concerts, very successful. In fact one of them ended up on Dr. Henry Louis Gates' of the African Americans *Many Rivers to Cross*, his Peabody and Emmy-award winning PBS series for example. We have one that's called "Jazz Plus" that allows us to have jazz at the center but it's jazz plus rock, jazz plus Latin, jazz plus rock, jazz plus classical. So that's another theme. You also have — we had one that was a singer series, that you give it a certain title. So the question is more for us, how does a particular group fit underneath the theme that we're presenting for the audience we're presenting to. So those are the real main

370 considerations certainly because — certainly not race. But you do want to have the right
371 fit for what you're trying to present.
372 MR: Yeah. And personalities and all that.
373 GT: Yeah. Absolutely. You know one of the things that, particularly when we've hired young
374 musicians I realized that I'm going to have to not only just hire and produce an event
375 featuring young musicians, but sometimes I actually need to get into a coaching modality
376 with them in the sense of, "Hey guys, this is entertainment too. This is entertainment. So
377 you need to communicate with your audience. You know, maybe you're interacting. You
378 tell some jokes or you let them know what song it is, and you give them a context to
379 connect with you and to connect with the music. It's got to be more than you just getting
380 up there blowing."
381 MR: Yeah. Listen to Cannonball Adderley and how he — and it's really interesting you say
382 that because I'm guessing that some of these younger musicians that don't get that may
383 have graduated from jazz schools.
384 GT: I think so. I think so, yeah.
385 MR: And they're not getting that.
386 GT: See the way it used to be, it used to be in music that you learned by the old crafts model,
387 the apprentice model. So as a beginner obviously you have to learn your craft, so you're
388 going to learn the basics in music. You're going to learn how to play your instrument,
389 how to play in tune if you're playing a woodwind instrument like we do or like I did and
390 you do. You've got your long tones, you've got to learn your scales in every key, you've
391 got to learn your chords you know. You develop your own personal sound — at least you
392 strive towards that. As a beginner usually that's not the case because you don't really
393 have an instrumental identity yet. But along the way you play in bands, so it's not just
394 you playing in your room by yourself on your instrument and shedding with records,
395 which is important. But you've got to play with other people. And through the process of
396 playing with other people you start to grow, because you're on that journey together and
397 you see how to communicate, listen, respond to other people. But in playing with — the
398 apprentice model had it where you would get with someone who is at another level and
399 learn from them you know. And the ideal is when you get a chance to be with a master of
400 the particular art form so that that master is, whether it's verbally through, you know,
401 when you're practicing and they instruct you, or just more psychically you know.
402 Because some leaders don't really explain a lot you know. But you get it you know. And
403 often times these masters are not just teaching about music. It's about life. It's about how
404 you comport yourself as a young man or a woman in this field out here you know. That's
405 one of the things that anyone who's going through that apprentice model, that's what they
406 tell you. They learned so much about life itself and relationships and such, not just

playing music though that's primary. So you know you have a basic — you have the apprentice, you have a journeyman, you have you know craftsman and master craftsman. So when you go through that process you are developing yourself instrumentally, being able to play in a group context until you get to a point where you yourself say, are a master on your instrument, with your own voice, your own particular approach. Influenced — you've got those other people on the stage with you — but you still have your own identity, your own sound, your own particular approach that's expressive of who you are. These days you have schools that have codified a particular way to learn how to play jazz. And so you have — and they serve their purpose. It's important to have a codification of an art form when you have institutional structures through which people learn how to do things. Especially when you don't have, first of all, the number of grand masters from the Golden Era less and less, that's one thing. And you have less and less bands run by masters. There's only a select number of slots in those bands you know. So when you had the big bands traveling, going on the road and you have bands in all these different venues, you had more opportunity for that. So there needs to be a way for a young person who wants to know how to play to do that. So that serves that purpose. But what has ended up happening in a lot of cases is that on a particular instrument you find a lot of the young players sound very similar. And you also find that they don't seem to — let me learn the history, you know, chronological history of the music and that's a necessary part of their study. They don't necessarily seem to learn that history on the instrument. A lot of times you have artists who will start — if they start in the 50s that would be good. Because the 50s is the epicenter. You have all these different things. But a lot of times they start in the 60s. Or the 70s.

MR: They start with Coltrane.

GT: Well they start with Coltrane but you've got some who start, you know, you've got trumpet players who start with Roy Hargrove. Now Roy Hargrove is a wonderful player. But Roy Hargrove was checking out Clifford Brown and Fats Navarro and Dizzy you know. They need to learn the history and traditions of your instrument. You know if you're a trumpet player, a jazz trumpet player, then you need to have Louis Armstrong, Roy Eldridge, Dizzy, and there's all kind of people, Buck Clayton, there's all kinds of people in there too you know, who are great players in their own right who you need to know. But on up. Not that you're going to play in Pop's style or Dizzy's style necessarily. But they are central to the development of the idiom. So if you are going to play in the idiom then you need to understand the continuum of that idiom. It just stands to reason you know? But a lot of times young folks are like well — and this is disturbing to me — "oh blues," you know. I'll tell you — I'm going to give you an anecdote that was really something. I told you when I was in high school and played in the stage band

and we played Spyro Gyra. Well when I was here I actually started doing some writing when I was here. I wrote for *The Spectator*, and I remember, I don't know if I did this for *The Spectator*, but I interviewed Jay Beckenstein, the lead alto player for Spyro Gyra. And I asked him about the blues. Jay Beckenstein says, "That wasn't my experience. I don't play the blues." And there was something in me that just got so turned off. Not because I so loved the blues myself, because I had to really get educated on what the blues meant. I had yet to really delve into the work of Ralph Ellison, Albert Murray, to find out the meaning of the blues or the meaning of blues music as I did later. But there was something in me that said that's something — then you have disconnected yourself from one of the founts, one of the tributaries that became jazz and that still is fundamental to jazz. And I find that these days a lot of young musicians, they might think as I did at one time, blues, that's old timey. You don't have to do that. Well if you're not going to confront the blues then how can you call yourself a jazz musician? Really. Really. All the masters, all the masters had to deal with the blues. You're going to talk about free jazz? Ornette Coleman? Well Ornette Coleman was grounded in the blues. You can't listen to Ornette Coleman and not realize that he was marinated in the blues. Okay? Come on man. Then you've got folks who have the audacity to not confront swing. You're talking about fundamental practices and values. Because swing is not just a musical practice. Swing represents a value and represents a certain meaning in the cultural dynamic of the music. So if you're not going to deal with blues and swing, not that you have to confine yourself on every song to playing something that's bluesy or swinging on every one, because that don't help it like that. Or you might choose, once you learn that, to try to extend or go beyond, or play something else that ain't jazz. That's your prerogative. But if you were to call yourself a jazz musician, and you are not going to confront blues and swing —

MR: You're doing yourself a large disservice.

GT: Absolutely. And a disservice to a public who may not know jazz history. And if you are either calling yourself a jazz musician or allowing yourself, because you are an instrumentalist say, to actually be called a jazz musician and you're not that — Kenny G is not a jazz musician. I'm not saying Kenny G can't play. Kenny G has a nice tone on the soprano sax, and I don't mean to just — you know there's a group of people who just knee jerk condemnation of certain people and Kenny G is one of them. But I'm using him as an example. He plays instrumental pop and instrumental R&B. Let's call it what it is. There's a market for that obviously.

MR: Herb Alpert. When I was a kid he was, and in fact I read a fact recently that Kenny G surpassed Herb Alpert as the largest selling instrumentalist. But Herb Alpert, no one

called him a jazz musician. He was playing instrumental pop music and it was very pleasant and stuff. So let's just call Kenny G an instrumental pop musician.

GT: Right. And that's okay. But there are people who get confused. Why do they get confused? Because you have radio stations that were playing things that they called jazz but that really wasn't jazz. Now you've got certain stations that are influenced more, like WRVR in New York in the late 70s that played jazz, what we call jazz, but they also played fusion, which is like a combination of jazz with rock and other elements. Okay. I'm not a purist though. I mean that's why I say it's okay if you want to play something else. And also because actually for me, what they call fusion is something that when I first got into the music I loved. And what I would do is I would — because interestingly enough, I don't think I've ever articulated this or written this. But what I used to do is, it was more for swing because I mean man I just love swinging. Because there was something about, because as a player, being in a context where you're playing in a band and you get a certain groove going, and it just is so uplifting. And when you're swinging, I mean when you think about the combination of a bass player walking, a drummer riding the cymbal — notice these are movement metaphors — the piano player comping accompanying. And that groove together creates what they call that swing feeling. For a soloist that's something that you can ride on, that you can fly with, that you can interact with. Maybe you're going to rub up against it where they're here and you're there. It creates this tension and release and this form of expression, this freedom that's so powerful. So if you are going to not express yourself in that medium and not have elements of the blues, then why would you want to call yourself a jazz musician? Now I'm not saying that there are not elements of the jazz tradition, what I would say is part of the jazz tradition, that counter-stated that, that went another direction where there's the song form or song stylings there's a whole part of the music that extended, you know, experimental part and stuff. But they are in part experimenting not only by incorporating other genres of music from classical to other styles, but it's also a counterstatement to what is that tradition. Which is valid. I mean art is about an expression but it's also about statement and counterstatement, so that when you as an artist are developing your own identity you incorporate certain people whose style you like or love, and you learn that, and the part of you expressing and becoming into your own and with your own identity, and then some that you don't like. And as you develop your own style you say well — that influences you too. So I don't like that. So what I do counters that. I don't really dig that you know. Or I like this. And that's just the nature of the way art is. This is not just music. This is in writing too. I once asked Albert Murray if James Baldwin was an influence on him. And he said, "Yes. He was an influence. He influenced me in what not to do." I'd never thought about it in that way.

MR: Yeah. You can learn something from things you don't like.

GT: Absolutely. Absolutely.

MR: Well before we run out of time here, let's talk about Albert Murray a little bit.

GT: Okay. What would you like to know?

MR: Were you influenced by him?

GT: Greatly. I mean Albert Murray is one of my intellectual heroes, and I consider him a mentor because I knew Mr. Murray. In the early 90s I wrote him a letter because I had a book project that I wanted to do at the time and I took a look at his work, the work of John Henrik Clarke who was a black American historian on the Black Nationalists line, and then Lerone Bennett, who was the editor of *Ebony* magazine and a political writer. So I called him up after writing this letter and he said, "Hey man, why do you want to put me with those guys?" In other words, why do you want to do a work where you're looking at me in comparison to them.

MR: He said that to you.

GT: He said that to me, yeah. But see Murray was, to some he was very cantankerous, argumentative you know. But he was at heart a teacher. I mean he taught at a number of schools but there were just people who he took under his wing and he was patient in his professorial and teacherly capacity. So I would go over to his place on 132nd off Lenox Avenue, which those of us who are Murrayites call the spyglass tree. That's one of his phrases. You know you have the little spyglass, you go into a tree and you have a spyglass that gave you a view of whatever you're looking at in a closer view. And *The Spyglass Tree* is the name of one of his novels. His second novel. I would talk to him, I would interview him, I read his work. He put me on to Michael James, who I mentioned earlier, and Michael and I became very close. So I consider myself a Murrayite in that sense. So his work is fundamental. In fact I'm about to do some work, some books dealing with his thought in more detail. So he wrote books like *The Omni-Americans* which I think if people would take a look at that book called *The Omni-Americans* more seriously they would have a richer conception of what being an Americans means and they would look much less at race and more towards culture. Okay. The Omni-American means all-American, but his point was that being an American means that you're going to have some kind of mixed mulatto something most of the time. And that's okay. Because most of us are mixed in some kind of way or another, you know, the genetic works that Henry Louis Gates is doing through some companies, and these shows that he has on PBS where he looks at the genetic history of usually famous people shows that these mixtures are just reality. Murray also wrote *The Hero and the Blues*, which takes a look at the blues and heroism from a literary context. He has *Stomping the Blues*, which is like a poetic of the blues which talks about the blues kind of every which way, looking at it

from the sacred and secular perspective, looking at it from a historical territory bands to the icons and heroes of the cannon. He also wrote, and this is non-fiction I'm talking about, the autobiography of Count Basie you know, *Good Morning Blues*, as told to Albert Murray. *The Blue Devils of Nada*, a contemporary approach to the American Aesthetic Statement I think it's called, and a book of poetry, four novels from *Train Whistle Guitar*, which he worked on for a long time, which I think may be his classic of fictional work, to *The Spyglass Tree*, which takes the main character, Scooter, who we are introduced to through *Train Whistle Guitar* and he's in college in [The] *Spyglass Tree*. Then you have *The Seven League Boots* where the main character is now an adult, a young adult, and he ends up going on the road with a character named the Bossman. And the Bossman is kind of a combination of Basie and Ellington and he's playing bass. And his last novel, *The Magic Keys*. So he was a great writer, an original thinker who, if more — if he were better known and his work were better known I think he would not only change the discourse and the conversation regarding race and taking it more in the direction of culture but it would also clarify things regarding the meaning and significance of blues in jazz, not only in American history but as a dynamic that really has been a powerful, has had such a powerful impact around the world. I mean just to give you one example, it was Murray who clarified that the blues as such as he calls it, is about you know, a sorrowful situation of being downtrodden and that kind of thing. But blues music is not about that. Blues music is part of a communal and ritual practice that allow people to actually counter, "stomp the blues." And he puts it in the context of when you have blues music and you're feeling good and you're dancing and stuff, that's part of like courtship rituals and leads to a fertility ritual, so we can perpetuate the species. So that's taking it out to like a very fundamental anthropological level. But a lot of people don't understand that. I mean I didn't understand that in high school. I was like the blues, all right. You know, talking about the blues and slavery, I don't want to deal with that.

MR: And you hear people moaning, yeah right. It's so damn fun to play.

GT: Absolutely. And folks who grew up with it knew it's fun to listen to. You know you actually listen to it to get rid of the blues you know.

MR: Yeah. One thing I love about playing the blues is you can't get lost. I mean you really have to try to get lost.

GT: Right, right.

MR: You know you can feel it coming around again every time and —

GT: Yeah. It cycles.

MR: It just lets you play without getting too distracted by trying to pay attention to complex chord changes and all that. Although you can make it complex also. So I think of it as

like the blues is like a chameleon. It's like let's play — we need something funky. Well we can play a 12-bar blues in funky. Or whatever. It can adapt.

GT: Well absolutely. I mean that's one of the things Ellington and so many others — you can play the blues all kind of which way. You can play it slow, you can play a stomp, fast blues, I mean all kind of different feeling and flavors and approaches is there with that fundamental blues. And then it connects — through like the pentatonic scale it connects to music around the world. So the blues is so fundamental to American music and like I say through the pentatonic scale it connects to music around the world. So then you have musicians who don't want to confront the blues and you're in America and you're playing jazz? If you're playing rock you can't not confront the blues. If you're playing country you can't not confront the blues.

MR: I remember Muddy Waters said, "The blues got pregnant and the baby was rock and roll."

GT: Yeah. Right, right, right, right. Yeah. Well then if the blues was — in that anecdote or metaphor if the blues was a woman then the father would be R&B. Because rock comes out of R&B. Especially through the person of Louis Jordan, who was jazz, R&B, entertainer, he had that whole thing.

MR: Well, to wrap up here, what's your feeling about the near future of jazz?

GT: Hmm. The near future of jazz. That's a good question. You know when I was here I had a radio show on WHCL and my very last show, the very last two songs I played, I said well what's the future of jazz going to be like. This was like '85 you know, spring of '85. And I said some people say it's going to be like this, and I played Jean-Luc Ponty with his guitar doing something that was very fusionesque. And I said but I kind of would like it to be like this — and I put on Art Blakey with Wynton Marsalis. Swinging you know. So I think that jazz has flowered in such a fashion that, as Branford Marsalis once said to me, there isn't these days the shared language, the lingua franca, as there was at one time, so that you have these different strains, these different offshoots where there are some people who are so much into complex time signatures, you know, nine, eleven, and seven-eight and all kinds of stuff, as opposed to or — not just as opposed to — but where straight four-four swing, maybe it's boring to them or something. But I would add that to the voice of the blues, voice of swing, and this need, the seeming need to go into all these complexities. But as Clark Terry, in that great documentary *Keep On Keeping On* said to a group of students at William Paterson University and Duke Ellington said once something along the lines that simplicity is one of the most complex things that you can do.

MR: Yeah. It's not easy to be simple.

GT: So but to answer your question, it's kind of hard to say. I can tell you what I wish. I want to make sure that as people experiment, as musicians try in their definition of their own style maybe in relation to a group of musicians that they play with even a generation, that they will continue to look at the sweep and continuum of the history of development, know it, know how to play aspects of that so they can always draw on that as they're trying to innovate or do something else. But I mean there's such a diversity that you find. So if you want this mixture, I mean there's folks from a South or East Indian background that incorporate Indian music into what they do. There are people from Eastern Europe who incorporate their own sound. And they should. They should. Because that's part of their own expression, their own background. But I would say, like with anything in life, you have your fundamentals and then you develop based on your fundamentals. Know your fundamentals if you're going to play in the art form of jazz, know the fundamentals and certain aspects of the fundamentals, blues, jazz, four-four swing, Latin — you can add that Latin tinge — you know there's a certain thing. You can play at a variety of tempos, from ballad to up-up tempo; learn how to play in before you play out. If you want to play out, to be able to play out then that's counterposing what in is. So learn in first you know. Get your basics down and then go from there.

MR: Well you're a good advocate for the music.

GT: Thank you, sir.

MR: This is obvious, but you know what you're talking about, and that's — we want the advocates to know what they're talking about.

GT: Thank you very much, Monk.

MR: So it's been a pleasure and I wish you the best of luck with your Albert Murray work.

GT: Thank you, sir.

MR: And your continued entrepreneurial skills.

GT: Thank you very much Professor Rowe.

MR: Thanks a lot.

GT: Yeah. Thank you.